

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, partly cloudy, a possible storm, high 82. **Tonight**, partly cloudy, warm, low 68. **Tomorrow**, partly cloudy, warm, a storm later, high 88. Weather map, Page B12.

VOL. CLXXV No. 60,854

© 2026 The New York Times Company

TUESDAY, APRIL 14, 2026

Prices in Canada may be higher

\$4.00



Hungarians celebrated on Monday in Budapest after the defeat of Prime Minister Viktor Orban the day before after 16 years in power.

STRAIT BLOCKADE OPENS SHOWDOWN ON ECONOMIC PAIN

**U.S. Cuts Lifeline as Tehran Bets on Risk
of High Inflation in Election Year**

By DAVID E. SANGER

WASHINGTON — President Trump’s decision to blockade all Iranian shipments out of or into the Strait of Hormuz starting Monday morning sets up the next great test in the Iran war: Which side can endure more economic pain, Tehran’s new leadership or Mr. Trump himself?

Almost everything about how this new turn in the war plays out is likely to look very different than what has unfolded so far.

Instead of directing missiles and bombs at military sites, missile emplacements and Iran’s defense industry, Mr. Trump will try to choke off the country’s lifeblood, the oil that accounts for more than 50 percent of its exports and just about all of the government’s revenue.

The president’s first hope, administration officials said on Sunday, is to force the government to surrender to the terms that Vice President JD Vance laid out in peace talks in Islamabad, Pakistan — and that Iran rejected, just as it did in negotiations in Geneva before the war began on Feb. 28. The list of terms starts with Iran’s agreement to turn over every ounce of its uranium stockpile, permanently dismantle its huge infrastructure for producing nuclear fuel and give up its claims to regulate traffic in the strait.

Failing an Iranian capitulation, Mr. Trump appears to still harbor the hope he expressed the first evening of the war: that a restive Iranian populace will rise up and overthrow the military-clerical regime that has guided the country since the revolution in 1979. But engineering that outcome is no easier than it was a month and a half ago.

For its part, Iran’s strategy appears to be one of waging the conflict in the global markets, where Tehran has discovered new powers. Acutely aware that they lost the military contest in the first five weeks, but performed above expectations in the information arena and in terrorizing their neighbors with well-aimed missile and drone strikes, the Iranians are betting that Mr. Trump’s tolerance for political pain is limited.

If no Iranian oil gets through the strait, prices could keep rising over time — some companies say they are planning for \$175 a barrel. The Iranians understand the potential political effects of continued inflation in the United States less than seven months before midterm elections.

“Soon you’ll be nostalgic for \$4 to \$5 gas,” Iran’s top negotiator and the speaker of its Parliament, Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf, warned American consumers after the failure of the talks he led with Mr. Vance. As of Monday

Continued on Page A6

DISTANCED European nations declined to take part in blocking the Strait of Hormuz. PAGE A6

FATIGUE Many Israelis believe the war in Iran has accomplished little. News Analysis. PAGE A8

IN RUINS Damage to civilian infrastructure across Iran includes schools and hospitals. PAGE A10

Iran, Feeling Bite of Sanctions, Found Economic Workarounds

By PATRICIA COHEN and ROBERT GEBELOFF

LONDON — For nearly 50 years, Iran has been treated as an outlaw, earning a spot as one of the most heavily sanctioned countries in the world for its nuclear and weapons programs, its support for terrorism, its human rights abuses and more.

But despite persistent efforts by the United States, the European Union, Britain and the United Nations Security Council to choke off Iran’s international trade and freeze assets, the country has managed to keep doing business with much of the world, a New York Times analysis shows.

The nation has exchanged goods with more than 170 nations since 2019, even as international restrictions have fueled inflation, soaring unemployment and civil unrest. Overall trade is down, but the country has imported much needed food, electronics and auto parts while it sells oil, gas, construction materials, specialty foods and thousands of other products. Sanctions hobbled Iran’s economy, but they have not broken its back.

“The expectation is that sanctions have isolated Iran from global trade, but that is not entirely the case,” said Esfandiyar Batmanghelidj, chief executive of the Bourse & Bazaar Foundation, a research organization based in London. “Iran’s trade has grown more complex over time in response to sanctions.”

The war with the United States and Israel has conspicuously shifted the country’s prospects. Iran’s blockade of shipping traffic in the Strait of Hormuz has interfered with its own ability to get ac-

Continued on Page A11



Tehran early this month. Sanctions have hobbled Iran’s economy, with overall trade down, but they have not broken its back.

ARTS C1-6

Daniel Radcliffe’s Co-Stars
For “Every Brilliant Thing,” the actor asks members of the audience to take part in the interactive show. PAGE C1

A Quick Change of Scenery
From a wedding banquet to a schoolroom in 90 seconds: One opera wastes no time shifting settings. PAGE C1

OPINION A18-19

Frank Bruni PAGE A18



NEWS ANALYSIS

Viktor Orban, Populist, Lost His Popularity

By ANDREW HIGGINS

BUDAPEST — Prime Minister Viktor Orban of Hungary was for years Europe’s pre-eminent political wizard, a leader endowed with uncanny insight into his people’s desires and fears, and the ability to steer political tides.

He won four thumping election victories in a row — more than any other current European Union leader — and declared liberal democracy passé long before President Vladimir V. Putin of Russia pronounced it finished, in 2019, or President Trump first won the White House, in 2016.

On Sunday, it became clear that Mr. Orban had lost his magic.

Peter Magyar, the opposition leader whose Tisza party scored a crushing victory in Hungary’s general election, told cheering crowds that they had ushered in “regime change.”

“You have worked a miracle,” he said. “Hungary has written history.”

What had really happened, however, was that Mr. Orban had failed to rewrite a basic rule of politics, particularly for populists: You have to be popular to win elections.

The result on Sunday did not represent an ideological earthquake or a sudden swerve among Hungarians from right to left, but rather something highly personal. Voters toppled a strongman leader who, increasingly cocooned in the flattery of sycophants and the praise of a sprawling propaganda machine, had lost his touch.

“The fall of the Orban regime

Continued on Page A5

Trump’s Volatile Talk Revives Doubts on Stability

By PETER BAKER

WASHINGTON — President Trump’s erratic behavior and extreme comments in recent days and weeks have turbocharged the crazy-like-a-fox-or-just-plain-crazy debate that has followed him on the national political stage for a decade.

A series of disjointed, hard-to-follow and sometimes-profane statements capped by his “a whole civilization will die tonight” threat to wipe Iran off the map last week and his head-spinning attack on the “WEAK on Crime, and terrible for Foreign Policy” pope

Onetime Loyalists Call President ‘Lunatic’ and ‘Insane’

on Sunday night have left many with the impression of a deranged autocrat mad with power.

The White House rejected such assessments, saying that Trump is sharp and keeping his opponents on edge. But the president’s eruptions have raised questions about America’s leadership in a time of war. While the country has

had presidents whose capacity came under question before, most recently the octogenarian Joseph R. Biden Jr. as he aged demonstrably before the public’s eyes, never in modern times has the stability of a president been so publicly and forensically debated — and with such profound consequences.

Democrats who have long challenged Mr. Trump’s psychological fitness have issued a fresh chorus of calls to invoke the 25th Amendment to remove the president from power for disability. But it is not just a concern voiced by partisans on the left, late-night comics

Continued on Page A8



“I thought it was me as a doctor,” President Trump said of the image of him in a white and red robe with light glowing in his hand.

Trump Denies Portraying Self As Jesus in Post

By KATIE ROGERS

WASHINGTON — The image showed President Trump in a white and red robe, commonly used in renderings of Jesus Christ and in Scripture prophesying his return. Bright golden light, which is used to depict divine intervention in religious imagery, radiated from Mr. Trump’s hand as he touched the forehead of a sick man. A woman observed the scene with her hands steeped in prayer.

As he received two bags of a McDonald’s food delivery to the Oval Office on Monday morning, Mr. Trump told reporters that he did not catch all that religious imagery. He said he had thought the image he had posted to his Truth Social account had depicted him not as Jesus — but as a physician.

“I thought it was me as a doctor,” Mr. Trump said of the social media post, which he deleted after an outcry. “Only the fake news could come up with that.”

Continued on Page A9

Swalwell May Not Be the Last Setback for California Democrats

By SHANE GOLDMACHER

The California governor’s race was supposed to give Democrats a chance to elevate a new party leader in the nation’s most symbolically significant liberal state, and fill a powerful perch with a progressive voice leading the opposition to President Trump.

Instead, the contest to succeed

Gov. Gavin Newsom has played out more like a series of unfortunate events, culminating with the demise of Representative Eric Swalwell’s campaign in a stew of sexual misconduct accusations.

He announced on Monday that he would resign from Congress.

The state’s most wide-open race for governor in a generation had begun with the potential field-

Departs the Governor’s Race, Then Congress

clearing candidacy of Kamala Harris, the former vice president. She was looking for her next step after losing the 2024 presidential race and consulted advisers and

friends about running to lead her home state.

But she opted against the race and is instead “thinking about” a third presidential bid.

Some Democrats salivated over a possible run by Senator Alex Padilla, one of the nation’s most prominent Latino leaders. He, too, passed.

Continued on Page A13

INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Stoking Fear in Myanmar
The military junta has brutalized the country for decades. But ordinary items — like flowers in one’s hair — can still get citizens arrested or worse. PAGE A4

NATIONAL A12-17

A Crush of Newcomers
Residents of a coastal county in South Carolina worry that rapid growth is threatening a rural way of life. PAGE A12

City-Owned Grocery to Open
Mayor Zohran Mamdani announced plans for a store in East Harlem that would offer discounts on food. PAGE A16

SPORTS B6-9

Feud on Ice Is Still Heated
The curling tensions between Canada and Sweden at the Olympics have carried over to a new league. PAGE B9

Assuming the Mantle

With his second straight Masters win, Rory McIlroy, with his father, has taken over the Tiger Woods role. PAGE B6



BUSINESS B1-5

Judge Tosses a Trump Lawsuit
A court said the president had not “plausibly alleged” actual malice in The Wall Street Journal’s reporting about a letter to Jeffrey Epstein. PAGE B1

Furniture Stores Struggling

Retailers are going bankrupt as record-low housing turnover leaves fewer people furnishing homes. PAGE B1

SCIENCE TIMES D1-8

Millions in Harm’s Way
A collapse of a glacier in Antarctica would accelerate sea-level rise in coastal cities around the world. PAGE D1

OBITUARIES B10-11

Feisty Leader of Daily News
Fred Drasner, a former cabdriver, took on rival papers in New York’s so-called tabloid wars. He was 83. PAGE B10

A Picasso of Plants

Pearl Fryar, a self-taught topiary artist, carved trees and shrubs into extraordinary shapes. He was 86. PAGE B11

